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How to Use This Card

Find your fabric, match the settings, and sew with confidence.

Each table gives you five answers at a glance: needle type, needle size, thread, stitch length, and iron setting. No guessing, no searching — just look it up and go.

Reading the tables

- 1 Identify your fabric** — check the garment care label or do a burn test on a small scrap.
- 2 Find the category** — lightweight, medium, heavy, knit or specialty.
- 3 Read across the row** — each column tells you one setting for your machine or iron.
- 4 Set your machine** — change the needle, adjust the stitch length, and thread the bobbin.
- 5 Test on a scrap** — always sew two layers of scrap before sewing the garment.

Do this

Print this card and pin it above your sewing machine. Having it in sight saves you from looking it up every time.

Lightweight Fabrics

Delicate fabrics that need a fine needle and gentle handling.

FABRIC	NEEDLE	SIZE	THREAD	STITCH LENGTH	IRON
Chiffon	Microtex	60/8	Fine polyester	2.0 mm	Low, no steam
Silk	Microtex	65/9	Silk or fine polyester	2.0 mm	Low, pressing cloth
Voile	Universal	65/9	All-purpose polyester	2.0 mm	Medium-low
Organza	Microtex	60/8	Fine polyester	1.8 mm	Low, no steam
Batiste	Universal	70/10	All-purpose polyester	2.0 mm	Medium
Lawn	Universal	70/10	All-purpose polyester	2.0 mm	Medium, light steam

Common mistake

Using a standard 80/12 needle on chiffon or organza — it punches visible holes that cannot be removed.

Medium-Weight Fabrics

The workhorses of your wardrobe — cotton, linen, poplin and blends.

FABRIC	NEEDLE	SIZE	THREAD	STITCH LENGTH	IRON
Cotton	Universal	80/12	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm	High, steam
Linen	Universal	80/12	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm	High, heavy steam
Poplin	Universal	80/12	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm	Medium-high
Chambray	Universal	80/12	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm	High, steam
Broadcloth	Universal	80/12	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm	Medium-high
Corduroy	Universal	80/12	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm	Medium, wrong side, no pressing
Wool (light)	Universal	80/12	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm	Medium, pressing cloth, steam

Do this

Pre-wash cotton and linen before altering — they can shrink up to 5% on the first wash, which changes your measurements.



Heavyweight Fabrics

Thick fabrics that require a stronger needle and slower sewing speed.

FABRIC	NEEDLE	SIZE	THREAD	STITCH LENGTH	IRON
Denim	Jeans	90/14 – 100/16	Heavy-duty polyester	3.0 mm	High, steam
Canvas	Jeans	100/16	Heavy-duty polyester	3.0 mm	High, steam
Twill	Jeans	90/14	All-purpose polyester	3.0 mm	Medium-high
Wool (heavy)	Universal	90/14	All-purpose polyester	3.0 mm	Medium, pressing cloth, steam
Upholstery	Jeans	100/16 – 110/18	Heavy-duty polyester	3.0 – 3.5 mm	Medium, test first

Common mistake

Sewing through multiple denim layers at full speed — slow down through thick seam intersections or the needle will snap.

Knit & Stretch Fabrics

Fabrics that stretch need a ballpoint needle and a stitch that moves with them.

FABRIC	NEEDLE	SIZE	THREAD	STITCH LENGTH	IRON
Jersey (cotton)	Ballpoint	75/11	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm (zigzag)	Medium, light steam
Interlock	Ballpoint	80/12	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm (zigzag)	Medium
Rib knit	Ballpoint	75/11	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm (zigzag)	Low-medium, no stretching
Lycra / spandex	Stretch	75/11	Stretch polyester	2.0 mm (narrow zigzag)	Low, no steam
Fleece	Ballpoint	90/14	All-purpose polyester	3.0 mm (straight or zigzag)	Low, no steam, no pressing
Ponte / double knit	Ballpoint	80/12	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm (zigzag)	Medium, pressing cloth

Do this

Use a walking foot or reduce presser foot pressure when sewing knits — it prevents the fabric from stretching and waving as it feeds.

Specialty Fabrics

Fabrics that need extra care — leather, velvet, lace and sheers.

FABRIC	NEEDLE	SIZE	THREAD	STITCH LENGTH	IRON
Leather / faux leather	Leather	90/14 – 100/16	Heavy-duty polyester	3.0 – 3.5 mm	No iron (use roller)
Velvet	Universal	70/10	All-purpose polyester	2.5 mm	Wrong side, velvet board
Lace	Microtex	65/9	Fine polyester	2.0 mm	Low, pressing cloth
Tulle / net	Microtex	60/8	Fine polyester	2.0 mm	No iron
Satin	Microtex	70/10	Fine polyester	2.0 mm	Low, wrong side

Common mistake

Pinning leather or faux leather — every pin hole is permanent. Use clips or tape instead.

Quick Iron Temperature Guide

One page to check before you press any fabric.

Too hot burns the fabric; too cool does nothing. Match the setting to the fibre, not the garment.

IRON SETTING	TEMPERATURE	FABRICS	STEAM?
Low (1 dot)	~110 °C / 230 °F	Synthetics, silk, acetate, nylon, lycra	No
Medium (2 dots)	~150 °C / 300 °F	Wool, polyester blends, rayon	Light steam, pressing cloth
High (3 dots)	~200 °C / 390 °F	Cotton, linen, denim	Yes, full steam

Before pressing — check

- ☐ Fabric fibre content (check the care label)
- ☐ Iron set to the correct temperature
- ☐ Pressing cloth ready for delicate fabrics
- ☐ Steam setting matches the fabric
- ☐ Test on an inside seam or scrap first

Do this

When a garment has mixed fibres (e.g., cotton–polyester blend), always iron at the LOWER setting of the two fibres to avoid damage.

Next Step

Keep this card next to your sewing machine. Before each alteration, look up the fabric and set your needle, thread and iron accordingly. Then open **The Complete Clothing Alterations Manual** and follow the guide for your project.